CHAPTER 8 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

Vicksburg

The fortress city on the bluffs that held the Mississippi — and the campaign that split the Confederacy in two. 1863.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

The fortress city on the bluffs that held the Mississippi — and the campaign that split the Confederacy in two. 1863.

Why can control of a single river decide the fate of a nation?

Why the River Mattered

"THE GIBRALTAR OF THE CONFEDERACY"

The Mississippi River was the spine of the continent — the highway for crops, troops, and trade. From the start, the Union's Anaconda Plan aimed to seize it and cut the Confederacy in half.

By 1863 the Union held both ends of the river. Only one great obstacle remained: Vicksburg, Mississippi, a city on high bluffs whose cannon commanded the water below. As long as Vicksburg held, the Confederacy was still whole.

"Admiral Porter's fleet running the rebel blockade of the Mississippi at Vicksburg, April 16, 1863" — lithograph, Currier & Ives, public domain (Library of Congress).

Running the Batteries

APRIL 16, 1863

Admiral David Porter ran his gunboats straight past Vicksburg's guns at night — a daring gamble that put the Union fleet below the city and set Grant's campaign in motion.

"Admiral Porter's fleet running the rebel blockade of the Mississippi at Vicksburg, April 16, 1863" — lithograph, Currier & Ives, public domain (Library of Congress).

A Bold March

GRANT'S GAMBLE

General Ulysses S. Grant did something risky: he cut loose from his supply lines, marched his army down the far side of the river, crossed below the city, and lived off the land as he drove inland.

He won a string of battles, captured the state capital at Jackson, and then turned back west to trap the Confederate army inside Vicksburg itself. When direct assaults failed, Grant settled in for a siege.

"Siege of Vicksburg, 1863" — chromolithograph, Kurz & Allison, public domain (Library of Congress).

47 days

THE SIEGE

For 47 days the Union army and Porter's gunboats pounded Vicksburg while cutting off all food. Soldiers and civilians alike were trapped. Families dug caves into the hillsides to survive the shelling; people ate mules, rats, and shoe leather.

On July 4, 1863 — the day after Gettysburg ended — the starving city surrendered. Some 29,000 Confederate soldiers laid down their arms.

Turning points, 1863–65 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

ABRAHAM LINCOLN, ON THE FALL OF VICKSBURG

The Father of Waters again goes unvexed to the sea.

A Confederacy Cut in Two

WHY IT MATTERS

With Vicksburg taken, the Union controlled the entire Mississippi. Texas, Arkansas, and most of Louisiana were sliced off from the rest of the Confederacy — their men and supplies now cut off from the war in the East.

Coming the very same week as Gettysburg, Vicksburg made the first week of July 1863 the great turning point of the war. The Confederacy would fight on for two more years, but it could no longer win.

"Siege of Vicksburg, 1863" — chromolithograph, Kurz & Allison, public domain (Library of Congress).

Read the Map

YOUR TURN

You'll use a map of the Mississippi and Lincoln's own words to practice geographic reasoning and historical significance — explaining why one river city mattered so much.